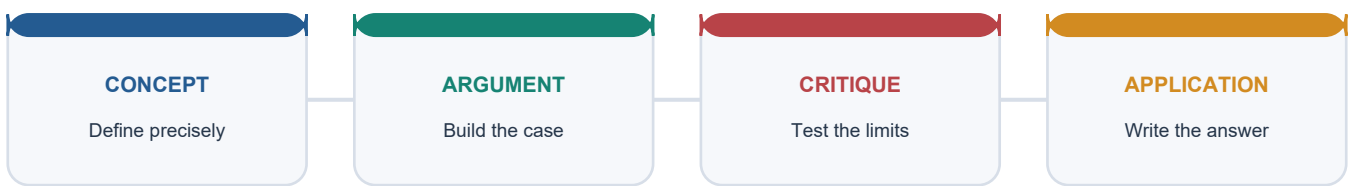


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

NITI Aayog - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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NITI Aayog - Solved Practice Workbook

Subject: Polity | **Control date:** 8 September 2026

Locked discipline: exactly 32 original MCQs before PYQs; ABCD repeated eight times; 128 unique option-specific explanations; 32 unique examiner traps; verified-PYQ wording and official-key discipline; exactly six original Mains models.

Exactly **32 original MCQs** appear before PYQs. Correct-option sequence: ABCD repeated eight times. Every question has four substantive option-specific explanations and one unique examiner trap.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1. Legal status

Which description of NITI Aayog is correct?

A. An executive, non-constitutional and non-statutory policy institution B. A constitutional commission under Article 280 C. A statutory authority created by the NITI Aayog Act, 2015 D. A parliamentary committee of both Houses

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The 1 January 2015 Union Cabinet Resolution is its creating source.
- **B:** Article 280 creates the Finance Commission, not NITI Aayog.
- **C:** No NITI Aayog Act created the institution.
- **D:** NITI is not a committee of Parliament.

Examiner trap 1: The word 'national' does not imply constitutional status.

MCQ 2. Institutional replacement

NITI Aayog directly replaced which institution?

A. The Finance Commission B. The Planning Commission C. The National Development Council D. The Inter-State Council

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The Finance Commission continues under Article 280.
- **B:** NITI replaced the executive Planning Commission in 2015.
- **C:** The NDC was a separate plan-era executive forum; it was not transformed into NITI.
- **D:** The Inter-State Council remains a distinct Article 263 mechanism.

Examiner trap 2: Replacement of one executive institution did not abolish every plan-era forum.

MCQ 3. No constitutional amendment

Which statement best describes the 2015 transition?

A. The Constitution inserted a new Part on national planning. B. Parliament enacted an ordinary statute abolishing the Planning Commission. C. Executive action replaced one executive policy body with another. D. The Supreme Court ordered creation of NITI Aayog.

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** No constitutional Part was inserted.
- **B:** No founding Act performed the transition.
- **C:** Both institutions rested on executive resolutions, so executive action changed the design.
- **D:** No judicial direction created NITI.

Examiner trap 3: Separate legal source from political importance.

MCQ 4. Power boundary

Which action can NITI Aayog NOT perform by its own authority?

A. Publish a policy strategy B. Convene Union-State policy dialogue C. Evaluate a programme D. Enact a binding law for all States

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Strategy preparation is within its advisory role.
- **B:** Federal dialogue is part of its convening role.
- **C:** Monitoring and evaluation fit its mandate.
- **D:** Only a competent legislature can enact binding law.

Examiner trap 4: A policy recommendation does not become law merely because the Prime Minister chairs NITI.

MCQ 5. Chairperson

Who is Chairperson of NITI Aayog?

A. The Prime Minister B. The President C. The Union Finance Minister D. The Vice-Chairperson

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The founding design places the Prime Minister in the chair.
- **B:** The President does not chair NITI.
- **C:** The Finance Minister may hold another institutional role but is not Chairperson by that office.
- **D:** The Vice-Chairperson is a separate appointed category.

Examiner trap 5: Chairperson and Vice-Chairperson are not interchangeable.

MCQ 6. Governing Council

Which description correctly identifies the Governing Council?

A. Only Union Ministers and NITI members B. Chief Ministers of all States and Union Territories with legislatures, and Lieutenant Governors of other Union Territories C. All Members of Parliament from the States D. Finance Commission members and State Finance Ministers

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Union officials alone would omit the federal territorial component.
- **B:** This follows the amended official membership formulation.
- **C:** Parliamentary membership is not the basis of the Council.
- **D:** Neither Article 280 membership nor State Finance Ministers define this Council.

Examiner trap 6: Use the officially specified CM/LG formula rather than saying vaguely 'all States'.

MCQ 7. Regional Council

A NITI Regional Council is best described as

A. a permanent constitutional chamber B. a statutory Zonal Council C. a specified-tenure forum for a particular issue affecting more than one State or a region D. a tribunal deciding inter-State water disputes

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The Resolution does not create a permanent constitutional chamber.
- **B:** Zonal Councils arise under the States Reorganisation Act, 1956.
- **C:** The founding Resolution provides this need-based design.
- **D:** Adjudication requires a separate legal route; a Regional Council is consultative.

Examiner trap 7: Time-bound NITI Regional Councils and permanent statutory Zonal Councils are different.

MCQ 8. Ex-officio category

The founding Resolution permits a maximum of four

A. full-time members B. Regional Councils C. special invitees D. ex-officio members from the Union Council of Ministers nominated by the Prime Minister

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** No such maximum is stated for full-time members in the foundational category list.
- **B:** Regional Councils arise according to issues, not a four-council cap.
- **C:** Special invitees are a separate expertise category.
- **D:** The maximum of four attaches to the ex-officio Union-minister category.

Examiner trap 8: Attach each numerical cap to the correct membership category.

MCQ 9. Part-time members

Which statement about part-time members is correct?

A. Up to two may be drawn on rotation from leading universities, research organisations and other relevant innovative organisations. B. They must be serving Governors. C. They are elected by the Governing Council. D. They are constitutionally guaranteed a six-year term.

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** This reproduces the bounded foundational category.
- **B:** Governorship is not the eligibility route.
- **C:** The Resolution does not prescribe such an election.
- **D:** No constitutional tenure protects this executive category.

Examiner trap 9: The 'up to two' cap belongs to part-time members, not all experts.

MCQ 10. Chief Executive Officer

Under the foundational design, the CEO is

A. elected by Chief Ministers B. appointed by the Prime Minister for a fixed tenure in the rank of Secretary to the Government of India C. appointed by the CAG D. a constitutional officer under Article 324

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The Council does not elect the CEO.

- **B:** This is the specified appointment and rank framework.
- **C:** The CAG has no such appointment role.
- **D:** Article 324 concerns the Election Commission.

Examiner trap 10: Fixed tenure in an executive resolution is not constitutional tenure.

MCQ 11. Two hubs

Which pair is correctly associated with NITI's institutional design?

A. Finance Hub and Audit Hub B. Legislative Hub and Judicial Hub C. Team India Hub and Knowledge and Innovation Hub D. Tax Hub and Grants Hub

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** NITI has no constitutional finance-and-audit dyad.
- **B:** It neither legislates nor adjudicates.
- **C:** The two hubs capture federal engagement and think-tank capability.
- **D:** Tax and grants powers belong elsewhere.

Examiner trap 11: Do not substitute generic government functions for the named two-hub design.

MCQ 12. Bottom-up planning

The official bottom-up aspiration most directly means

A. all national policy must be approved by Gram Sabhas B. district rankings become binding on States C. Parliament delegates taxation to villages D. credible plans should develop from village level and aggregate upward

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Local participation does not create a universal veto over national policy.
- **B:** Rankings remain informational instruments.
- **C:** Taxation powers follow constitutional and statutory law.
- **D:** This is the founding objective's planning direction.

Examiner trap 12: Bottom-up planning is an aspiration and process, not automatic fiscal devolution.

MCQ 13. Planning Commission status

The Planning Commission was

A. an executive, non-constitutional and non-statutory body B. a constitutional body under Article 263 C. a statutory body under the Finance Commission Act D. a judicial commission

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** It was created by Government Resolution in 1950.
- **B:** Article 263 concerns an inter-State council route.
- **C:** The Finance Commission's legal framework is unrelated.
- **D:** The body did not exercise judicial power.

Examiner trap 13: NITI differs from the Planning Commission mainly in role and principle, not broad legal status.

MCQ 14. National Development Council

Which statement about the NDC is safest?

- A. It is Article 279A's constitutional council. B. It was a separate executive plan-era forum whose approval/coordination role was tied to the old planning architecture. C. It is another name for NITI's Governing Council. D. It determines the divisible pool under Article 280.

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The constitutional council in Article 279A is the GST Council, not the NDC.
- **B:** This preserves its historical role without inventing formal abolition or legal succession.
- **C:** The bodies are institutionally distinct.
- **D:** Tax devolution recommendations belong to the Finance Commission.

Examiner trap 14: Say the plan-era role lapsed; do not claim a constitutional abolition without evidence.

MCQ 15. Plan/non-plan distinction

The plan/non-plan expenditure distinction was ended through

- A. the 2015 NITI founding Resolution B. an Article 280 recommendation automatically amending the Constitution C. the Union Budget 2017-18 reform D. a judgment converting plan expenditure into capital expenditure

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The founding Resolution did not perform this budget reclassification.
- **B:** A Finance Commission cannot automatically amend the Constitution.
- **C:** Official Budget 2017-18 documents did away with the distinction.
- **D:** No such judicial conversion explains the reform.

Examiner trap 15: Do not collapse NITI's creation and the later budget reform into one act.

MCQ 16. Cooperative federalism

Which is the best test of substantive cooperative federalism in NITI?

- A. Whether NITI can command every State B. Whether States receive meaningful voice, reasoned response and implementation support C. Whether the Governing Council becomes a second chamber D. Whether every meeting ends in unanimity

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Command would contradict the advisory federal design.
- **B:** Voice, response and capacity test the quality of cooperation.
- **C:** The Council is not Parliament.
- **D:** Federal cooperation can include reasoned disagreement.

Examiner trap 16: Attendance is evidence of a forum, not proof of meaningful cooperation.

MCQ 17. Competitive federalism

Which tool most directly exemplifies competitive federalism?

A. Comparable indicators and public benchmarking among jurisdictions B. A binding NITI decree C. CAG certification of every rank D. A constitutional tax surcharge imposed by NITI

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Comparison can create reputational incentives and peer learning.
- **B:** NITI has no decree-making power.
- **C:** CAG does not certify NITI league tables as a constitutional duty.
- **D:** NITI cannot impose a tax.

Examiner trap 17: Competition operates through information and reputation, not coercion.

MCQ 18. SDG India Index

The SDG India Index is best understood as

A. a Finance Commission award formula B. a benchmarking and localisation instrument for State and UT SDG performance C. a binding compliance code D. a CAG audit report

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** It does not determine Article 280 awards.
- **B:** This captures its comparative policy use.
- **C:** An index does not create legal commands.
- **D:** It is not an Article 151 audit report.

Examiner trap 18: A composite score is neither a legal entitlement nor a causal finding.

MCQ 19. Aspirational model

The core '3C' mechanism of the Aspirational Districts approach is

A. command, control and compliance B. capital, courts and cesses C. convergence, collaboration and competition D. consultation, codification and conviction

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** The programme is not designed as coercive command.
- **B:** These terms do not define its operating method.
- **C:** The official model combines existing schemes, joint effort and comparative progress.
- **D:** The fourth option invents a legal-process framework.

Examiner trap 19: Remember the mechanism, not volatile district counts.

MCQ 20. Delta ranking

Delta ranking primarily measures

A. constitutional powers B. absolute population C. the total number of schemes D. incremental improvement over a period

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** District constitutional power is not the ranking object.
- **B:** Population size alone is not delta.

- **C:** Administrative activity count is not necessarily progress.
- **D:** Delta captures change and can recognise movement from a low base.

Examiner trap 20: Delta performance and absolute development level answer different questions.

MCQ 21. Aspirational Blocks Programme

Which description is correct?

A. A 2023 programme applying a related outcome-oriented approach at block scale
 B. A constitutional amendment creating block governments
 C. A Finance Commission grant category
 D. A replacement for Panchayats

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** ABP extends focused monitoring to the more granular block scale.
- **B:** No constitutional amendment created it.
- **C:** It is not itself an Article 280 grant category.
- **D:** Panchayats remain constitutional/local-government institutions under State law.

Examiner trap 21: A programme scale is not a new tier of government.

MCQ 22. DMEO

DMEO is

A. a department of the CAG
 B. an attached office of NITI Aayog supporting monitoring and evaluation
 C. the GST Council's audit wing
 D. a constitutional tribunal

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** CAG audit has a separate constitutional and statutory basis.
- **B:** Official DMEO material identifies this relationship and role.
- **C:** GST Council has no such wing.
- **D:** DMEO does not adjudicate disputes.

Examiner trap 22: Functional autonomy should not be inflated into constitutional independence.

MCQ 23. Atal Innovation Mission

Atal Innovation Mission is best classified as

A. a constitutional commission
 B. a statutory market regulator
 C. an initiative under NITI Aayog supporting innovation and entrepreneurship
 D. a ministry controlling all research expenditure

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** No constitutional article creates AIM.
- **B:** No Act establishes it as a regulator.
- **C:** This is the correct institutional location and broad purpose.
- **D:** NITI and AIM do not control all research budgets.

Examiner trap 23: Programme ownership does not imply regulatory monopoly.

MCQ 24. Finance Commission

Which body is constitutionally constituted to make specified recommendations on Union-State tax distribution and grants?

A. NITI Aayog B. Governing Council C. National Development Council D. Finance Commission under Article 280

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** NITI gives policy advice, not constitutional devolution awards.
- **B:** The Governing Council is not a fiscal commission.
- **C:** The NDC was a plan-era forum.
- **D:** Article 280 establishes the Finance Commission route.

Examiner trap 24: Do not assign the divisible pool to NITI.

MCQ 25. Inter-State Council

The Inter-State Council differs from NITI because it is

A. a council contemplated by Article 263 for specified inquiry, discussion and advice functions B. NITI's permanent Regional Council C. a statutory tax tribunal D. the body that audits Union accounts

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Article 263 provides the constitutional enabling basis.
- **B:** The two are distinct institutional mechanisms.
- **C:** It is neither a tax body nor a tribunal by this description.
- **D:** CAG audits are governed elsewhere.

Examiner trap 25: Constitutionally enabled does not mean the Council adjudicates every dispute.

MCQ 26. GST Council

Which body is created by Article 279A?

A. Finance Commission B. GST Council C. NITI Governing Council D. National Development Council

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Article 280, not 279A, concerns the Finance Commission.
- **B:** Article 279A creates the GST Council.
- **C:** NITI's Council rests on executive resolution.
- **D:** The NDC has no Article 279A status.

Examiner trap 26: Shared federal membership does not make two councils legally identical.

MCQ 27. Ministries

After NITI recommends a policy requiring expenditure or rules, the ordinary next step is

A. automatic legal enforcement B. implementation by NITI against unwilling States C. decision, budgeting and legal/administrative action by the competent government or ministry D. certification by the Election Commission

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Advice is not self-executing law.
- **B:** NITI has no general enforcement power.
- **C:** Competent authorities must adopt and implement the proposal.

- **D:** The Election Commission is institutionally unrelated.

Examiner trap 27: Follow the authority chain beyond the recommendation.

MCQ 28. CAG boundary

Which statement correctly distinguishes DMEO/NITI from the CAG?

A. NITI submits constitutional audit reports under Article 151. B. DMEO certifies net proceeds under Article 279. C. NITI removes the CAG for poor evaluation. D. CAG performs constitutionally grounded public audit; NITI/DMEO monitor and evaluate policy performance.

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Article 151 reports arise from CAG audit.
- **B:** Article 279 certification is a CAG function.
- **C:** NITI has no removal power over the CAG.
- **D:** The distinction separates legislative financial accountability from policy learning.

Examiner trap 28: Evaluation and constitutional audit may use evidence, but they are not interchangeable.

MCQ 29. Institutional strength

Which is NITI's most defensible comparative strength?

A. Flexible convening of governments and expertise around cross-sector policy problems B. Power to override State legislation C. Exclusive authority to approve every public project D. Judicial enforcement of development targets

Answer: A.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Executive flexibility and networks fit its actual design.
- **B:** NITI cannot override a legislature.
- **C:** Project approval is distributed across lawful authorities.
- **D:** It has no judicial power.

Examiner trap 29: Judge NITI against its catalytic role, not powers it does not possess.

MCQ 30. Accountability reform

Which reform best fits NITI's advisory character?

A. Give every recommendation immediate legal force B. Publish agenda access, recommendation-response tracking and methods while retaining implementation authority with competent governments C. Transfer Article 280 to NITI by executive order D. Allow rankings to replace legislative budget scrutiny

Answer: B.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Automatic force would bypass legal authority and federal choice.
- **B:** This increases traceability without creating a super-ministry.
- **C:** An executive order cannot transfer a constitutional function.
- **D:** Indicators cannot replace democratic financial control.

Examiner trap 30: Accountability reform should clarify responsibility, not centralise power.

MCQ 31. Data risk

When an indicator becomes a high-stakes target, the principal governance risk is

A. that constitutional articles disappear B. that every data point becomes secret C. gaming or tunnel vision may improve the metric without improving the underlying outcome D. that NITI gains criminal jurisdiction

Answer: C.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Measurement does not alter constitutional text.
- **B:** Secrecy is not logically inevitable.
- **C:** This is the Goodhart-type distortion relevant to rankings.
- **D:** No criminal jurisdiction follows.

Examiner trap 31: Always pair league tables with data-quality checks and evaluation.

MCQ 32. Integrated proposition

Which combined statement is correct?

A. NITI is constitutional and allocates tax devolution. B. NITI is statutory and its Governing Council enacts binding plans. C. NITI is a CAG-supervised tribunal for State disputes. D. NITI is an executive advisory institution that convenes federal dialogue, supports strategy and evaluation, but cannot legislate, adjudicate or constitutionally allocate funds.

Answer: D.

Option-specific explanations:

- **A:** Both status and fiscal claim are false.
- **B:** No statute creates NITI and the Council is not a legislature.
- **C:** Neither audit supervision nor tribunal status exists.
- **D:** This integrates source, function and limits accurately.

Examiner trap 32: In a composite option, verify every clause rather than accepting one true phrase.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified PYQ source and official-key discipline

- **2018 GS-III Q11:** the audited local routing ledger securely establishes the year, paper, question number, directive, marks, word limit and demand concerning principles followed by NITI Aayog versus the erstwhile Planning Commission. The controlled local set does not preserve an independently verified exact official stem, so the workbook uses a neutral rendering rather than quotation. UPSC publishes no official Mains model answer; the model below is examiner-grade, not official.
- **2019 Prelims GS-I Q19:** the audited local routing ledger establishes an objective demand on the institutional setup of Atal Innovation Mission. A verified local official key and exact controlled stem/options are unavailable, so no option or official answer is reconstructed.

Verified routed PYQ 1 - UPSC GS-III 2018, Q11 - 15 marks, 250 words

Neutral audited rendering: Discuss how the principles followed by NITI Aayog differ from those followed by the erstwhile Planning Commission.

Demand: same legal footing + different planning principles, federal method, instruments and fiscal leverage + balanced effectiveness judgment.

Examiner-grade model (183 words; ceiling 250):

NITI Aayog and the Planning Commission share executive legal status, but follow different governing principles. The Planning Commission, created by resolution in 1950, combined central plan formulation with plan-resource leverage.

States negotiated within a Five-Year Plan framework, and the National Development Council operated as the associated political forum.

NITI Aayog, created by Union Cabinet Resolution on 1 January 2015, shifts the emphasis to cooperative federalism, bottom-up planning, strategic advice, monitoring and knowledge networks. Its Governing Council includes State and Union Territory leadership; competitive federalism uses comparative indices and programmes such as the Aspirational Districts Programme. Unlike the Planning Commission, NITI neither allocates plan funds nor approves State plans.

The change improves flexibility, peer learning and separation of advice from fiscal transfer. Yet it weakens direct leverage, and Union agenda control, uneven State participation and data-driven simplification can limit cooperation. Finance Commission transfers and ministry-controlled schemes remain institutionally separate.

Thus the difference is not constitutional status but operating philosophy: directive plan-and-allocation gave way to persuasive strategy-and-coordination. Effectiveness depends on whether transparent evidence and genuine State voice can compensate for the loss of fiscal power.

Verified routed PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2019, Q19 - demand only

Audited demand: institutional setup arrangement of Atal Innovation Mission.

Safe learning result: Atal Innovation Mission is an initiative under NITI Aayog. It is not a constitutional commission, statutory regulator or ministry. Because the exact controlled stem/options and a verified official key are unavailable locally, this workbook does not invent a solved option.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE - EXACTLY SIX MODELS

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Explain NITI Aayog's legal status and the principal limits that follow from it.

Model answer (139 words; ceiling 150):

NITI Aayog is the National Institution for Transforming India, constituted by Union Cabinet Resolution on 1 January 2015. No constitutional Article or Act of Parliament creates it; therefore it is an executive, non-constitutional and non-statutory institution.

This source gives flexibility. The Union executive may redesign membership, priorities and internal arrangements without constitutional amendment. NITI can prepare strategy, convene Union-State dialogue, publish indices and support monitoring and evaluation.

The same source marks its limits. Its recommendations are not law. It cannot impose a plan on a State, adjudicate an intergovernmental dispute, levy tax, determine Article 280 devolution, approve State plans or perform the CAG's audit role. A competent ministry, legislature or government must adopt and implement proposals.

Hence NITI's authority is persuasive and coordinative: flexible enough to shape policy, but legally unable to substitute for constitutional bodies or elected governments.

Examiner logic: claim -> named institutional evidence -> analysis of mechanism or consequence -> explicit qualification and proportionate conclusion.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Describe the composition of NITI Aayog and explain the purpose of its Governing and Regional Councils.

Model answer (147 words; ceiling 150):

The Prime Minister chairs NITI Aayog. Its institutional core includes a Vice-Chairperson appointed by the Prime Minister, full-time members, up to two rotational part-time members from relevant academic or research organisations, up to four ex-officio Union ministers nominated by the Prime Minister, a fixed-tenure CEO in Secretary rank, special invitees and a secretariat.

The Governing Council brings together Chief Ministers of all States and Union Territories with legislatures and Lieutenant Governors of other Union Territories. It is the principal Union-State/UT forum for development priorities, not a legislature or fiscal commission.

Regional Councils are different: the founding Resolution permits need-based councils for a specific issue affecting more than one State or region, for a specified tenure, with concerned territorial leaders and invited expertise.

The design combines political voice and professional capacity. However, consultation remains advisory, and concentrated agenda-setting and appointments require transparent follow-up to sustain federal trust.

Examiner logic: claim -> named institutional evidence -> analysis of mechanism or consequence -> explicit qualification and proportionate conclusion.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: Examine NITI Aayog's contribution to cooperative and competitive federalism.

Model answer (209 words; ceiling 250):

NITI Aayog treats federalism as both partnership and performance. Cooperative federalism operates through the Prime Minister-chaired Governing Council, the Team India approach, issue-specific Regional Councils and State-facing capacity support. These mechanisms can bring territorial experience into national priorities, expose implementation barriers and spread workable State practices.

Competitive federalism operates through comparable indicators, public rankings and monitored programmes. The SDG India Index benchmarks State and Union Territory progress, while the Aspirational Districts and Blocks programmes use convergence, collaboration and competition, including attention to incremental improvement. Such information can focus administrations and create reputational incentives without formal coercion.

The contribution is nevertheless conditional. NITI recommendations are non-binding and the institution lacks the Planning Commission's former plan-allocation leverage. The Union retains substantial agenda and appointment control; State participation may be uneven. Rankings can reward data optimisation, obscure unequal starting conditions and convert complex welfare outcomes into a single score. NITI also cannot replace constitutional devolution, State autonomy or local planning bodies.

Reform should therefore provide States formal agenda access, publish reasoned response and action matrices, strengthen State policy institutions, and independently verify indicator methods and data.

NITI has created a useful federal process, but its success depends on whether consultation changes decisions and competition improves citizens' outcomes rather than merely league-table positions.

Examiner logic: claim -> named institutional evidence -> analysis of mechanism or consequence -> explicit qualification and proportionate conclusion.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: Assess the Aspirational Districts and Blocks model as an instrument of outcome-oriented governance.

Model answer (197 words; ceiling 250):

The Aspirational Districts Programme, launched in January 2018, and the Aspirational Blocks Programme, launched in 2023, concentrate administrative attention on lagging territories. Their operating logic is convergence of existing schemes, collaboration across Union, State and field administrations, and competition through monitored indicators. District and block granularity can reveal bottlenecks hidden by State averages, while delta measures recognise recent improvement from a low base.

This architecture can improve review discipline, encourage problem-solving and spread local practices. It also suits NITI's actual powers: because NITI does not control every scheme or field department, it uses convening, data and reputation to align actors.

However, dashboard movement is not automatically an outcome or causal impact. Administrative data may be incomplete, delayed or strategically reported. A narrow indicator can divert effort from unmeasured needs, and delta improvement can coexist with a low absolute level. Programme attention cannot substitute for adequate finance, local democratic participation or durable State capacity.

The model should therefore disclose metadata and revisions, combine level and change measures, commission independent evaluations, include citizen feedback, and connect findings to State and local planning.

The aspirational approach is a valuable management mechanism, not a new constitutional tier or self-proving development success.

Examiner logic: claim -> named institutional evidence -> analysis of mechanism or consequence -> explicit qualification and proportionate conclusion.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Critically compare NITI Aayog with the erstwhile Planning Commission and evaluate whether the transition improved India's planning architecture.

Model answer (230 words; ceiling 250):

The Planning Commission and NITI Aayog were both created by executive resolution, so the 2015 transition changed institutional function rather than constitutional status. The Planning Commission worked through Five-Year Plans, central plan formulation, State-plan discussions and resource leverage. The National Development Council formed part of this plan-era political architecture.

NITI Aayog replaced that model with strategic advice, cooperative federalism, bottom-up aspiration, monitoring, evaluation and knowledge networks. Its Governing Council gives State and Union Territory leaders a common forum. Comparative indices, Aspirational Districts and DMEOs provide informational and learning instruments. NITI neither allocates plan funds nor approves State plans; Finance Commission devolution, ministry budgets and schemes remain separate. The 2017-18 abolition of plan/non-plan classification was a later budget reform, not NITI's founding act.

The transition improved flexibility, reduced the conflict between advisory planning and discretionary allocation, and encouraged policy experimentation. Yet it also removed fiscal leverage without creating a fully accountable long-horizon planning settlement. Executive appointment and agenda control, irregular federal engagement, institutional overlap and weak recommendation tracking can reduce credibility.

Reform should not recreate central command. A predictable Governing Council cycle, State agenda rights, published response matrices, clearer ministry-NITI role charters and independent evaluation safeguards would strengthen the advisory model.

Thus India moved from directive resource planning to indicative coordination. The architecture is more flexible and federal in design, but effectiveness depends on transparent follow-through and genuine State influence.

Examiner logic: claim -> named institutional evidence -> analysis of mechanism or consequence -> explicit qualification and proportionate conclusion.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Evaluate the democratic and institutional accountability of NITI Aayog and suggest reforms without turning it into a super-ministry.

Model answer (233 words; ceiling 250):

NITI Aayog exercises soft but significant public influence. It frames strategies, convenes governments, publishes comparative indices, supports targeted programmes and houses monitoring and innovation functions. Yet it rests on an executive resolution rather than a dedicated statute, and its advice often enters policy through diffuse channels. This creates an accountability problem: influence may be substantial while responsibility for acceptance, rejection and outcomes remains unclear.

Federal accountability is also contested. The Governing Council includes territorial executives, but agenda control and core appointments are Union-executive centred. Fiscal dependence can weaken the equality of consultation. Democratic scrutiny is indirect because NITI does not enact budgets or laws, while ministries implementing its advice remain answerable through ordinary parliamentary and legislative mechanisms.

Data tools add another risk. Rankings can improve visibility and competition, but opaque weights, weak administrative data or target gaming may distort priorities. Institutional overlap with ministries, intergovernmental forums and evaluation bodies can blur ownership.

Reform should preserve advisory flexibility while making influence traceable. States should receive formal agenda-proposal routes; major recommendations should have public response and action matrices; methods, data

revisions and evaluation limitations should be disclosed; independent evaluation should be separated from programme advocacy; and parliamentary committees may periodically examine institutional performance. Role charters should identify the lead ministry and NITI's bounded contribution.

NITI should become a more transparent platform and credible knowledge broker, not a binding planner, fiscal authority or parallel executive government.

Examiner logic: claim -> named institutional evidence -> analysis of mechanism or consequence -> explicit qualification and proportionate conclusion.